

A loop goes somewhere

A loop goes somewhere. · Curiosity day

Name _____

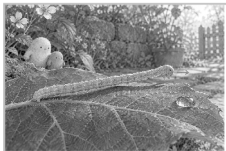
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A green arch rises on a leaf. "A tiny bridge!" says Little. Then the arch flattens and the head reaches ahead. Big watches beside the path. This is an inchworm, a kind of caterpillar. How can bending help it get somewhere?



The front legs grip the leaf. The rear comes closer, lifting the long middle into a loop. Near the rear are fleshy grips called prolegs. "No walking legs under that middle!" Little notices. With its ends closer, the body must bend.



Now the prolegs anchor the rear: they hold it in place. The front reaches ahead as the body straightens. Once the front grips, the rear can catch up again. "One end holds while the other moves," Little says. A loop becomes a journey.



Little sketches the head before a vein fork, then beyond it. The changed positions are evidence: clues that can support an idea. "It traveled past the fork!" That is an inference, an idea drawn from clues. The same leaf vein makes the comparison fair.



"Does every loop go one inch?" Little asks. The name sounds like measuring, but real steps vary. Little draws a pretend route instead. Its distances are invented. A model helps answer a math question without pretending the leaf picture is a ruler.



Little imagines a later chapter. The caterpillar becomes a pupa, then changes into a moth. This change of body form is metamorphosis. It takes time. Little sketches the stages. "A new shape after all those loops!"

Think about it: What evidence shows the head traveled rather than only bending in place? Why compare it with the same vein fork? During the reach, what anchors the rear? Predict what could happen if that grip slipped, and explain why.